

What the System Remembers: What the Numbers Hide

系统记住了什么：数字隐藏了什么

Theme: 科学、技术与互联网 · New: 45 · Review: 18 · Planned cumulative progress: 45/6, 127

English Story

The numbers hid the **main product**: trust. A **list** of four hundred tokens, a **standard** of measurement that nobody had signed, and a **principle** that the group had agreed on in the morning were all that stood between the service and the next audit.

The **theory** was elegant and the practice was not. An **object** in the system could be exchanged for a **key**, a **key** for a **match**, a **match** for a **wheel** of **electricity**, and the whole **exchange bound** the user to a contract nobody had read. “A **flag** on a **digital** form is not a signature,” the **analyst** said.

The **alarm** had been patched twice, and the **patch** had a **defect**. A **reverse** of the **battery** polarity in the **assembly**, a **crystal** in the **elevator** sensor, and a **developer** who had left the company: the **assembly** line of small errors had one **characteristic** in common, and it was invisible to the **accounting**.

The **instrument** that measured the **response** had a **zero** point nobody had calibrated since the previous century. “If the base is wrong, the **transformation** is theatre,” the **regulator** said. A **calendar** of releases, an **anchor** for the **bracket**, and a **token** in the **conductor's** hand: the **automation** was only as good as the person who watched it.

The **intermediate** step, which everyone wanted to skip, was the plain one: ask the user what the **light** on the **sun-facing** panel actually meant to them. After the third pass, finally, they pulled the report and waited at the **gate** for the answer — and the answer was not in the numbers at all. At the end, the level of detail was the problem. “**AIDS** does not care about our **calendar**,” the **analyst** said. “We might analyze a thousand results and still not thank the person who waited.” The **engine** of the current report, the **conductor** of the morning shift, and the panel facing the **sun**: none of them could tell down from up in the chart. A century of **accounting** had taught them one thing: the **standard** is the **instrument**, and the **instrument** is the person holding it in the morning.

中文翻译

这些数字掩盖了主要的产品：信任。一份四百个代币的清单、一项没人签署过的计量标准，以及小组在早上达成的一条原则，就是这项服务与下一次审计之间的全部屏障。

理论是优雅的，实践不是。系统中的一个物体可以换一把钥匙，一把钥匙换一场比赛，一场比赛换一个电力的轮子，而整个交换把用户绑定到一份没人读过的合同上。“数字表格上的一面旗子不是签名，”分析师说。

警报被修补过两次，而那个补丁有一个缺点。装配中电池极性的反接、电梯传感器里的一块晶体，以及一位已经离职的开发者：这条小错误的装配线上有一个共同特征，而它对会计是不可见的。

测量反应的那台仪器，自上个世纪以来就没有人校准过它的零点。“如果基点是错的，那个变换就是戏剧，”监管者说。一份发布日历、一个支架的锚点，以及指挥者手中的一个代币：自动化的好坏，只取决于看着它的那个人。

每个人都想跳过的那一步，恰恰是最朴素的一步：去问用户，那块朝向太阳的面板上的灯，对他们究竟意味着什么。第三轮之后，他们终于抽回了报告，在门口等待答案——而答案根本不在数字里。到最后，细节的层级本身就是问题。“艾滋病不在乎我们的日历，”分析师说，“我们也许分析了一千个结果，却仍然不会感谢那个等待的人。”这份现行报告的引擎、早班的售票员，以及朝太阳的那块面板：它们中没有一个能在图表里分清上和下。一个世纪的会计学教会了他们一件事：标准就是仪器，而仪器就是早上拿着它的那个人。

Core Vocabulary · 核心词汇

Word / Pronunciation	Context meaning / source example
main mein POS: n	n. 主要部分, 干线, 体力, 力量, 主群组; a. 主要的, 重要的, 全力的; [计] 主群组 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. any very large body of (salt) water; n. a principal pipe in a system that distributes water or gas or elect...
product 'prɒdʌkt POS: n	n. 产品, 结果, 乘积; [化] 生产物 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. an artifact that has been created by someone or some process; n. a quantity obtained by multiplication; n. a...
light laɪt POS: n	n. 光, 光亮, 灯, 日光, 发光体, 光源, 杰出人物, 火花, 眼光; a. 轻的, 少量的, 轻微的, 轻快的, 轻浮的, 明亮的... Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. (physics) electromagnetic radiation that can produce a visual sensation; n. any device serving as a source...
theory 'θiəri POS: n	n. 理论, 学说, 原理, 意见, 推测; [化] 理论 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a well-substantiated explanation of some aspect of the natural world; an organized system of accepted know...
standard 'stændəd POS: n	n. 标准, 规格, 旗, 军旗, 本位; a. 标准的, 合规格的; [计] 标准 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a basis for comparison; a reference point against which other things can be evaluated; n. a board measure ...
list lɪst POS: n	n. 目录, 名单, 明细表, 布条, 条纹, 列表, 序列, 数据清单; vt. 列出, 列于表上, 记入名单内, 装布条; vi. 列于表... Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a database containing an ordered array of items (names or topics); v. give or make a list of; name individu...
principle 'prɪnsɪpl POS: n	n. 原则, 原理, 主义; [化] 原理 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a basic generalization that is accepted as true and that can be used as a basis for reasoning or conduct; n...
response rɪ'spɒns POS: n	n. 反应, 回答, 响应; [计] 应答 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a result; n. a phrase recited or sung by the congregation following a versicle by the priest or minister; n. ...
sun sʌn POS: n	n. 太阳, 日, 日光, 阳光; vt. 晒; vi. 晒太阳 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the star that is the source of light and heat for the planets in the solar system; n. a person considered a...
object 'ɒbdʒekt POS: n	n. 物体, 目标, 目的, 对象, 宾语, 客体; vi. 反对, 抱反感; vt. 提出...来反对; [计] 对象 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a tangible and visible entity; an entity that can cast a shadow; n. (grammar) a constituent that is acted u...
exchange ɪks'tʃeɪndʒ POS: n	n. 交换, (电话) 交换局, 交换机, 汇兑, 交易所; v. 交换, 交易, 兑换; [计] 交换; 电话局 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. chemical process in which one atom or ion or group changes places with another; n. a mutual expression of v...
key ki: POS: n	n. 钥匙, 键, 解答, 关键, 要害, 基调, 线索, 答案, 暗礁; vt. 调音, 锁上, 提供线索; vi. 使用钥匙; [计] 键, ... Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. metal device shaped in such a way that when it is inserted into the appropriate lock the lock's mechanism...
match mætʃ POS: n	n. 比赛, 火柴, 对手; vt. 使相配, 使比赛, 与...竞争; vi. 结婚, 相配; [计] 比较 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. lighter consisting of a thin piece of wood or cardboard tipped with combustible chemical; ignites with fri...
engine 'endʒɪn POS: n	n. 引擎, 发动机, 机车; vt. 安装发动机于 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. motor that converts thermal energy to mechanical work; n. something used to achieve a purpose; n. an instrum...
assembly ə'sembli POS: n	n. 与会者, 集会, 装配, 组件; [化] 装配 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a group of machine parts that fit together to form a self-contained unit; n. a group of persons who are gat...
instrument 'ɪnstrʊmənt POS: n	n. 工具, 手段, 仪器; [化] 仪器 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a device that requires skill for proper use; n. the means whereby some act is accomplished; n. a person used...
analyst 'ænalɪst POS: n	n. 分析者, 精神分析学家; [化] 分析员; 化验员 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. someone who is skilled at analyzing data; n. an expert who studies financial data (on credit or securities)...
gate geɪt POS: n	n. 门, 牌楼, 大门, 通道, 闸; vt. 装门于; [计] 门; 栅 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a movable barrier in a fence or wall; n. a computer circuit with several inputs but only one output that ca...
AIDS eɪdz POS: n	n. 艾滋病(获得性免疫缺陷综合征); [计] 高级综合数据系统, 先进交互调试系统, 自动图解文档编制系统; 美国决策学学会, 信息自动显示... Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a serious (often fatal) disease of the immune system transmitted through blood products especially by sexu...

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characteristic ˌkærəktəˈrɪstɪk POS: n	n. 特性, 特征, 特色; a. 特性的, 特有的, 有特色的; [计] 阶; 指数 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a distinguishing quality; n. the integer part (positive or negative) of the representation of a logarithm; ...
wheel hwi:l POS: n	n. 轮子, 车轮, 轮, 方向盘, 旋转, 机构, 重要人物; vt. 使旋转, 转动, 使转向; vi. 旋转, 转弯, 盘旋 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a simple machine consisting of a circular frame with spokes (or a solid disc) that can rotate on a shaft ...
electricity ˌilekˈtrɪsɪti POS: n	n. 电, 电流, 电学, 热情, 电力供应; [化] 电学; 电 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a physical phenomenon associated with stationary or moving electrons and protons; n. energy made available ...
analyze ˈænəlaɪz POS: vt	vt. 分析, 细察, 分解; [机] 分析 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. consider in detail and subject to an analysis in order to discover essential features or meaning; v. make a ...
digital ˈdɪdʒɪtəl POS: a	a. 数字显示的, 数字的; n. 数字仪表, 数字式电子表(或时钟); [计] 数字, 数字式 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. displaying numbers rather than scale positions; a. relating to or performed with the fingers; a. of a circuit ...
flag flæg POS: n	n. 标志, 旗标, 旗子, 信号旗, 菖蒲; vt. 悬旗, 打旗号, 铺石板; vi. 无力地下垂; [计] 标志; 属性标记命令 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. emblem usually consisting of a rectangular piece of cloth of distinctive design; n. a rectangular piece of ...
alarm əˈlɑ:m POS: n	n. 惊恐, 警报, 警钟; vt. 使惊恐, 警告; [计] 报警信号 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. fear resulting from the awareness of danger; n. a device that signals the occurrence of some undesirable event ...
patch pæʃ POS: n	n. 片, 补缀, 碎片, 斑, 傻瓜; vt. 补缀, 掩饰, 拼凑, 平息; [计] 修补; 拼凑 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a piece of cloth used as decoration or to mend or cover a hole; n. a short set of commands to correct a bug ...
accounting əˈkaʊntɪŋ POS: n	n. 会计学, 帐单, 清帐; [计] 帐户处理, 记帐 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a convincing explanation that reveals basic causes; n. a system that provides quantitative information about ...
bound baʊnd POS: n	n. 跃, 回跳, 范围, 边界; a. 受约束的, 装有封面的, 有义务的, 关联的, 被束缚的, 准备去...的, 便秘的; vi. 跳跃... Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. form the boundary of; be contiguous to; a. confined by bonds; a. held with another element, substance or material ...
reverse rɪˈvɜ:s POS: n	n. 相反, 背面, 倒退, 挫折, 失败; a. 反面的, 相反的, 反向的, 颠倒的; vt. 使颠倒, 使逆转, 使倒退, 使反向; vi... Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a relation of direct opposition; n. the gears by which the motion of a machine can be reversed; n. an unfortunate ...
battery ˈbætəri POS: n	n. 电池, 殴打; [化] 蓄电池 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. group of guns or missile launchers operated together at one place; n. a device that produces electricity; m... Example: n. group of guns or missile launchers operated together at one place; n. a device that produces electricity; m...
transformation ˌtrænsfəˈmeɪʃən POS: n	n. 变形, 变质, 变化, 改革, 变换; [化] 转化; 变换 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a qualitative change; n. (mathematics) a function that changes the position or direction of the axes of a coordinate system ...
crystal ˈkristl POS: n	n. 水晶, 水晶装饰品, 结晶; a. 水晶的, 水晶一样的, 透明的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a solid formed by the solidification of a chemical and having a highly regular atomic structure; n. a crystal ...
developer dɪˈveləpə POS: n	n. 开发者; [计] 显影器 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. someone who develops real estate (especially someone who prepares a site for residential or commercial use) ...
elevator ˈelɪveɪtə POS: n	n. 电梯, 升降机; [化] 提升机 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. lifting device consisting of a platform or cage that is raised and lowered mechanically in a vertical shaft ...
zero ˈziərəʊ POS: n	n. 零, 零点, 零度, 无, 乌有, 最低点; a. 零的, 没有的; vt. 调零, 对(炮火等)作协调校正; [计] 零 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a mathematical element that when added to another number yields the same number; n. the point on a scale from ...
defect dɪˈfekt POS: n	n. 缺点; [医] 缺损, 缺陷 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. an imperfection in a bodily system; n. a failing or deficiency; n. an imperfection in an object or machine; v... Example: n. an imperfection in a bodily system; n. a failing or deficiency; n. an imperfection in an object or machine; v...
calendar ˈkælɪndə POS: n	n. 日历, 日程表; vt. 列入表中; [计] 日历 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a system of timekeeping that defines the beginning and length and divisions of the year; n. a list or register ...

Word / Pronunciation	Context meaning / source example
regulator 'regjuleɪtə POS: n	n. 调整者, 校准者, 校准器, 调整器, 标准钟; [化] 调节剂; 调节器 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. any of various controls or devices for regulating or controlling fluid flow, pressure, temperature, etc.; n...
intermediate .ɪntə'mi:diət POS: n	n. 中间物, 调停者, 中级; a. 中间的, 中级的; vi. 起媒介作用; [计] 中级 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a substance formed during a chemical process before the desired product is obtained; a. lying between two e...
anchor 'æŋkə POS: n	n. 锚; vt. 抛锚停泊, 使固定; [计] 锚 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a mechanical device that prevents a vessel from moving; n. a central cohesive source of support and stabili...
bracket 'brækit POS: n	n. 支架, 括弧, 托架; vt. 装托架, 括入括弧; [计] 方括号; 括号 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a category falling within certain defined limits; n. either of two punctuation marks ('<' or '>') used in c...
conductor kən'dʌktə POS: n	n. 领导者, 指挥者, 售票员, 向导; [化] 导体 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the person who leads a musical group; n. a substance that readily conducts e.g. electricity and heat; n. the...
token 'təʊkən POS: n	n. 表征, 记号, 代币; a. 象征的, 表意的; [计] 记号 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. an individual instance of a type of symbol; n. something serving as a sign of something else; n. a metal or...
automation .ɒ:tə'meɪʃən POS: n	n. 自动化, 自动操作; [计] 自动学; 自动化 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the act of implementing the control of equipment with advanced technology; usually involving electronic ha...